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ALL THE KINGS' SONS: THE ROLE AND TASKS OF THE DUMU-NITA EN AT EBLA (SYRIA, 24TH CENT. BCE)

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1. Introduction

Information on family ties is abundant in the archives of the ancient city of Ebla. As in other cuneiform archives, individuals are mostly identified through their patronymic ('A son/daughter of B', where B is the father), although other kin terms rarely appear. As a result of this scribal habit, information on the most important families connected to royal Palace G and the city is plentiful; however, some of an individual's primary kin relationships (parents, spouse[s], children, siblings) can only be inferred; the same stands true for secondary kinship ties.

Terms of kinship are comparative descriptions of connections established through marriage or by line of descent: they describe the position of an individual with respect to other members of the same kin group. Since the royal family was the city's most important social group together with the ministers' families, the study of an individual's role and functions cannot leave out of consideration their connections to the extended kin groups. Both families ruled over and managed a large territory, dictating the political agenda: the interconnections between them have been recognized early in Ebla studies and are so profound that Eblaite relative chronology is generally divided into segments

* This paper is based on a section of my doctoral dissertation (Scarpa 2019, 75-81): it further explores the role of the royal sons and also takes into account new documents I could not include in that work (Samir 2019; Catagnoti – Fronzaroli 2020). This work has been published under the auspices of the International Association for Assyriology (IAA) Dissertation prize 2021. Abbreviations: 75.1234 = (TM.)75.(G.)1234; *A* = *ARET*, *Archivi Reali di Ebla, Testi*; AAM = Annual Account of Metals; *CAD* = *The Assyrian Dictionary of the Oriental Institute of the University of Chicago*, Chicago, 1956–2010; *DRS* = Cohen 1976–; EST = Ebla Sparse Texts (digital editions available on the *Ebla Digital Archives* Project's website; see Milano – Maiocchi 2011); *M* = *MEE*, *Materiali Epigrafici di Ebla*; MAT = Monthly Account of Textiles; *VE* = Vocabolario di Ebla = Pettinato 1982.

according both to the ministers' offices and the kings' reigns (see Fig. 1).[1] Understanding the relativeness of any individual's position within such larger families is thus of primary importance to the assessment of their role and functions in the broader social context. An accurate investigation and reorganization of data concerning kinship is thus a fundamental precondition to the understanding of social ties. Although royal sons (dumu-nita en) frequently appear in the administrative record, their status has yet to be investigated in depth. Taking into account their relative kinship ties with respect to other members of the royal family, this study set out to examine the role and functions of the royal sons at Ebla during the age of the archives.

The kings' relatives mentioned in the administrative record of Palace G are their sons (dumu-nita en), daughters (dumu-mi$_2$ en), wives and female relatives (dam en). The scribes of the archives recorded their presence in dozens of transactions, each one listing them as the recipients of various goods. These sections of the monthly and yearly accounts of garments are similarly structured, to the point that the names of the kings' relatives appear in the same order. However, the structure of these lists offers a puzzling representation of the Palace G elite. The first systematic study of the kings' female relatives (dam en) was reported in 1989,[2] by Tonietti, who demonstrated that slow but steady structural changes characterize the group of the court ladies over the years. These lists have since been used as an important dating tool since they allow scholars to establish temporal relationships between dozens of documents. In the case of the dam en, the disappearance of a court lady from the record can be explained with the woman's death or the departure of a daughter for a foreign court. By the same token, a new name appears when the king acquires a new wife or a female relative is, sometimes under unclear circumstances, included in the group. Surprisingly, this does not stand true for the group of royal sons. The dumu-nita en appear in the administrative record in a different series of lists concerned exclusively with the kings' male offspring.[3] Very little is currently known about them; this study aims to address this gap in the existing literature. In this paper, I shall demonstrate that the dumu-nita en lists undergo a different temporal evolution from that which characterizes the dam en lists. Data concerning the dumu-nita en proves that the lists referring to them are an accounting representation of reality; they do not offer a full picture of the royal sons as a social group nor of its evolution over time. Evidence suggests that some among the royal sons were involved in diplomatic activities, while others had religious obligations: the administrative record reflects this separation of duties, which appears to be related to their position within the royal family.

1. The sequence of AAMs established by Archi and Biga (2003, esp. 6-8) is the most commonly adopted chronological framework: years are abbreviated according to the ministers in charge (*e.g.*, Ar. = ArruLUM, Ib. = Ibrium, I.Z. = Ibbi-zikir).
2. See Tonietti 1989. For an update of the data concerning the court ladies, see Scarpa 2021a. It is now widely accepted that 'dam en' does not indicate exclusively the kings' wives. [75.1263 = *A* XIX 2] (list K$_3$), for example, lists eight dam en maḫ ('senior' wives), three royal daughters, one wife (possibly of inferior rank), three wet-nurses, and two more royal daughters.
3. There are, of course, exceptions to this rule, such as [75.1535 = *A* XV 26] obv.VIII:15-IX:12 (discussed below), where royal sons and daughters appear together. However, in most cases, male and female relatives appear in different groups. This distinction does not necessarily correspond to a complete separation of physical spaces or duties according to gender roles: men and women of the elite appear together in the official cult texts (discussed below), and the queen appears next to the king on several diplomatic occasions. It appears to me that the separation between male and female relatives in the documents of Great and Small Archive is first and foremost administrative.

1.1 The royal sons: *status quaestionis* and research gap

Since the beginning of Eblaite studies, it appeared clear that the kings' sons maintained their title and status after their father was succeeded by a new king. This consideration motivates my translation of dumu-nita en as 'royal son(s)' or 'kings' son(s)' in place of the commonly accepted 'son(s) of the king'. Furthermore, no direct evidence suggests Igriš-Ḫalab[4] was related by blood to his successors, although the consanguinity between Irkab-damu's and Iš'ar-damu's offspring is now considered a fact.[5] Royal son Maḫra-damu, for example, already appears in archaic lists,[6] and he is still addressed as dumu-nita en in documents dated to Ibrium's vizierate.[7] However, his specific kin bond to the king during this period cannot be ascertained: Maḫra-damu could have been king Iš'ar-damu's brother (if he was Irkab-damu's son) or his uncle (if he was Igriš-Ḫalab's son). However, he could have also been unrelated to the king if Igriš-Ḫalab was not his successor's father. Unfortunately, the scribes of the royal archives exclusively addressed the king by his title; as a consequence, data on the paternity of royal sons is almost nonexistent. Therefore, the main conundrum with regard to the dumu-nita en is their relative position with respect to the other members of the royal family: there are, in fact, no self-evident elements linking them to a specific generation (*i.e.*, a step in the line of descent).[8]

The accounting activity of Great Archive L.2769 is firmly tied to the events concerning the reigns of kings Irkab-damu and Iš'ar-damu (see chart in Fig. 1). However, the individuals mentioned in the administrative record of Palace G belong to at least four different generations. Since the elite is by far the most represented part of society in the administrative record, the

4. Given the uncertainty that still surrounds many aspects of Eblaite onomastics, in this paper I adopt conventional normalizations of personal names. According to Archi – Biga (2003, 6-7) the most ancient documents date to the reign of king Igriš-Ḫalab (*ig-ri*$_2$*-iš-ḫa-lab*$_x$[LAM]). He was succeeded by Irkab-damu (*ir*$_3$*-kab-da-mu*), who probably reigned for about seven years, while Ebla's last king, Iš'ar-damu (*iš*$_{11}$*-ar-da-mu*), reigned for about thirty-five years.
5. Lady Dusigu appears in the texts with the title ama-gal en ("mother of the king") during Iš'ar-damu's reign. Despite lack of any direct evidence, she is generally considered to be Irkab-damu's wife: in fact, although she never appears as dam *ir*$_3$*-kab-da-mu*, she belongs to the group of the dam en dating to his reign. Her role at court thus substantiates the hypothesis that Irkab-damu was Iš'ar-damu's father. However, at Ebla, the new king most likely 'inherited' his predecessors' wives and female relatives: although no self-evident proof of levirate marriage is available for Ebla, the group of the court ladies certainly included all female relatives of Ebla's kings.
6. I use the adjective 'archaic' to define the period roughly coinciding with Irkab-damu's reign. The documents drafted during this early phase clearly exhibit features which do not appear in later documents. In particular, MATs dated to this period (Pomponio 2008; Pomponio 2013) are less rich in detail and often syntactically more ambiguous. Furthermore, other elements suggest that a change in the administrative practice had been introduced at the beginning of Ibrium's mandate (Archi 1991, 204-21; Archi 2003, 21-29).
7. Ibrium (*ib-ri*$_2$*-um*) and his son Ibbi-zikir (*i-bi*$_2$*-ẓi-kir*) fulfilled the role of vizier during Iš'ar-damu's reign. Ibbi-zikir's son Dubuḫu-ʾAda (*du-bu*$_3$*-ḫu-*$^{(\text{dingir})}$*ʾa*$_3$*-da*) also played a primary role in Ebla's political panorama. However, he never took his father's place due to Ebla's unexpected demise.
8. I use the term 'generation' in its socio-anthropological sense, *i.e.*, kin descent. On the different meaning associated with the term, see Kertzer 1983, 126-132. The word 'generation' is often used, especially in sociology, with the meaning of 'birth cohort' (*i.e.*, a group of individuals born during the same period who experience common social events). As it emerges from the present study, the concept of birth cohort cannot be applied to the study of Ebla's society: it is not yet possible to identify which social events were experienced by the same individuals. However, the available information on kinship relationships makes it possible to identify the most relevant steps in the line of descent during the period covered by the archives.

following considerations are based on the kin relationships referring to the two most important Eblaite families: the kings' and the viziers'. Since at Ebla the vizier cooperated with the king in the administration of the city, several synchronisms can be established between the two families.

The four generations can be reconstructed as follows:

1. Igriš-Ḫalab's generation // viziers Darmia and Tir, ArruLUM: mentions of individuals belonging to this generation are limited to the most ancient documents. Darmia (*dar-mi-a*) and Tir (*ti-ir*) appear among the 'lords' (lugal) in the earliest mu-ku$_x$(DU) documents[9] and were active during Igriš-Ḫalab's reign. Both survived Igriš-Ḫalab but had been replaced by ArruLUM during Irkab-damu's last years of reign. Darmia, Tir, and ArruLUM were not kinsmen.
2. Irkab-damu (*i.e.* Igriš-Ḫalab's children) // vizier Ibrium: although Ibrium held the position of vizier during Iš'ar-damu's reign, he was older than the king. Evidence suggests he belonged to the generation of king Igriš-Ḫalab or Dusigu (Iš'ar-damu's mother), and that Iš'ar-damu was a child when he became king.[10]
3. Iš'ar-damu (*i.e.* Irkab-damu's children) // vizier Ibbi-zikir: in the second half of Iš'ar-damu's reign, Ibbi-zikir replaced his father Ibrium as vizier.
4. Ir'ag-damu (*i.e.* Iš'ar-damu's children) // Dubuḫu-'Ada: king Iš'ar-damu's and Ibbi-zikir's sons arose to a prominent position during Ebla's final years. It seems most likely that they would have become the city's new king and vizier had Ebla not fallen.

As previously stated, lack of direct data on paternity prevents us from linking the royal sons to any of these generations. Likewise, the scribes rarely indicated in the texts an individual's female line of descent. Therefore, the only royal son whose parents have been safely identified is crown prince Ir'ag-damu: with his full sister Kešdut (*keš$_2$-du-ut*), he is addressed as son of both the king and the queen.[11]

A further element complicating our understanding of the royal sons' social status is the lack of information regarding their lives, activities, and position at court. They are never associated with a profession or function (with a few exceptions, discussed below). In most cases, we thus only know their names and the events they attended; about their role in these events, however, little can be said. The publication of new documents since the findings of Archi (1988a) brings new insight on this particular social group.

The first section of this paper will present the data available concerning the dumu-nita en: starting from the first prosopography concerning this social group published in 1988, new data shall be presented with a particular focus on tablets published in later years. All available evidence shall then be considered and reorganized taking into consideration scholarly works published in the last

9. Doubts still persist in Eblaite studies on the meaning of the sign DU, despite Krecher's (1987) contribution to the topic. See also Sallaberger 1996, 182.
10. Biga 2016, 202-203.
11. Kešdut appears in the record both as the queen's ([75.2426] obv.XI:11-13: *keš$_2$-du-ut* dumu-mi$_2$ *MA-LIK-TUM*; "Kešdut, daughter of the queen"; quoted in Archi 2017, 294n5) and as the king's daughter ([75.2283 = EST 001] rev.II^{ii}:1-5: šu-nigin$_2$ 3 *li-im* 2 *mi-at* 90 gu$_4$ / mu-ku$_x$(DU) / nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$ / *keš$_2$-du-ut* / dumu-mi$_2$ / en; «Total: 3,200 oxen; income for royal daughter Kešdut's bridewealth»). Likewise, Ir'ag-damu was the queen's ([75.10074] obv.XVIII:15-17: *il$_2$-'a$_3$-ag-da-mu* dumu-nita *MA-LIK-TUM*; quoted in Archi 2017, 292n5) and the king's son ([75.1273 = *A* IV 5] obv.VII:1-8: 1 tug$_2$-NI.NI 2 *BU-DI* zabar šu$_2$+ša/ dam / ga-du$_8$ / *il$_2$-'a$_3$-ag-da-mu* / dumu-nita / en / e$_3$ / uru-bar; "1 NI.NI garment, 2 bronze toggle-pins [of the value of] twenty [shekels, for] the wet-nurse of royal son Ir'ag-damu [who/when she?] left [for the] city outskirts.").

four decades, especially studies concerning Ebla's relative chronology and the royal family. Raw prosopographical and chronological data are presented in the Appendix.

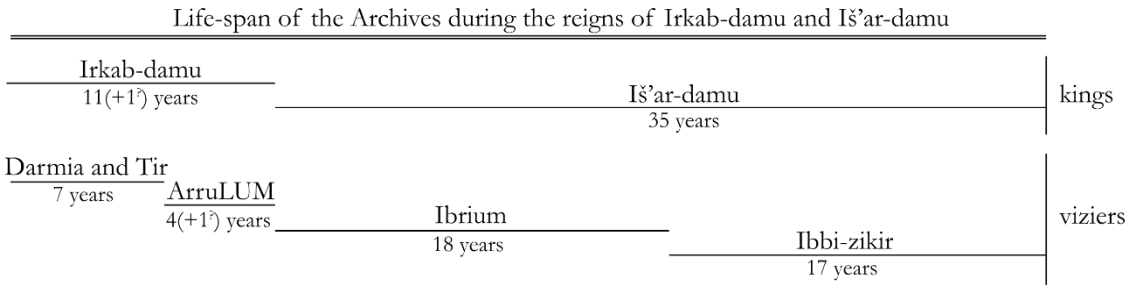

Fig. 1: Chronological chart of Ebla's kings and viziers. After Archi – Biga 2003 and Archi 2016.

2. Old and new data on the royal sons

2.1 The dumu-nita en so far

In 1988, Archi published the first detailed summary of a series of lists referred to the Palace G elite;[12] these sequences of personal names (often arranged in the same order) record the recipients of garments, precious items, and other goods. Archi immediately recognized the recursive structure characterizing the lists of dumu-nita en: according to data available in 1988, he identified two main list types, dividing the royal sons into two groups (hereafter indicated as Groups 1 and 2, see Table 1).[13] Group 1 consists of eight individuals, some among them already appearing in archaic documents (Irkab-damu/ArruLUM); Group 2 consists of nine individuals who appear exclusively in later documents (Iš'ar-damu/Ibrium, Ibbi-zikir). These lists tend to be ordered in the same fashion, as the following examples show:

> **[75.1322 = *A* XIX 8]** rev.I:18-II:10: 5 ʾ*a*$_3$-*da-um*^{tug2}-II / 2 ˹aktum^{tug2}˺ 5 ib$_2$+III sa$_6$ gun$_3$^{tug2} / ***maḫ-ra-da-mu*** / *wa* / ***i-da-ni-ki-mu*** / *wa* / ***i*$_3$*-lum-a-ḫu*** / ***i-in-***^{dingir}ʾ***a*$_3$*-da*** / ***šu-ra-da-mu*** / dumu-nita / en; "5 cloaks, 2 ˹tunics˺, 5 embroidered good quality waistbands, (for) royal sons Maḫra-damu, and Ida-nikimu, and Ilum-aḫu, I'in-ʾAda, Šura-damu".
>
> **[75.1337 = *A* XIX 13]** rev.V:16-VI:8: [5 ʾ*a*$_3$-*da-um*^{tug2}-II]? / ***maḫ-ra-da-mu*** / *wa* / ***i-da-ni-ki-mu*** / *wa* / ***i*$_3$*-lum-a-ḫu*** / ***i-in-***^{dingir}ʾ***a*$_3$*-da*** / ***za-a-da-mu*** / dumu-nita [e]n; "[5 cloaks]?, (for) royal sons Maḫra-damu, and Ida-nikimu, and Ilum-aḫu, I'in-ʾAda, Za'a-damu (= Šura-damu?)".[14]

12. Archi 1988a (hereafter referred to also as *ARES* I). Archi's work on the dumu-nita en is part of a broader study on Ebla's prosopography by Archi, Biga, and Milano (1988) which includes the kings' and viziers' kin (wives, offspring, and other relatives), as well as other important social groups (judges, overseers of the kunga$_2$-equids, and musical performers).
13. Archi 1988a, 223-224, Tables I-II.
14. On *za-a-da-mu* as a variant of *šu-ra-da-mu*, see also Samir 2019, 204. The parallelism between the two passages suggests the person mentioned in [75.1337 = *A* XIX 13] is in fact Šura-damu.

Group 1	Group 2
Maḫradamu	Iksubdamu
Ilumaḫi	Zedamu
Idanikimu	Gadum
I'in-^{d}'Àda	Zibdamu
Šuradamu	Sagdamu
Arwa	Ibtedamu
Zudu	Ilzidamu
Ḫaba	NEardamu
	Irkabrizu

Table 1: Main groups or royal sons according to Archi 1988a (Tables I-II, pp.223-224).

Overall, Archi was able to identify forty-one lists of dumu-nita en and fifty royal sons. Lists end in most cases with the label dumu-nita en, as in the following example:

> **[75.1681 = *A* IV 19 = *M* 7 24]** rev.III:14-IV:8: 5 '*a*$_3$-*da-um*^{tug2}-II 5 ib$_2$-III^{tug2} sa$_6$ gun$_3$ / i$_3$-giš sag / *maḫ-ra-da-mu* / *i*$_3$-*lum-a-ḫi* / *šu-ra-da-mu* / *ar-wa* / *zu*$_2$-*du* / **dumu-nita** / **en**; "5 cloaks, 5 embroidered waistbands of good quality, (for) the purification ceremony[15] (for) royal sons Maḫra-damu, Ilum-aḫi, Šura-damu, Arwa, Zudu".

The seventeen royal sons of Groups 1 and 2 appearing in the lists also appear elsewhere in the administrative record, alone or in small groups, as shown in the following passage:

> **[75.1457 = *A* XV 25]** obv.I:6-8: 1 aktum^{tug2} / *i-da-ne-gi-mu* / dumu-nita en; "1 tunic, (for) royal son Ida-negimu (= Ida-nikimu)".

However, prosopographical data suggests that a few lists lacking the label dumu-nita en should not be considered lists of royal sons. Passages such as [75.1775 = *M* 7 48] obv.I:1-II:12, quoted below, include individuals who do not belong to the group of the royal sons:

> **[75.1775 = *M* 7 48]** obv.I:1-II:12: 21 dul$_3$^{tug2} gun$_3$ / 10 aktum^{tug2} / lu$_2$ e$_2$ siki / e$_3$ / 11 aktum^{tug2} / lu$_2$ e$_2$ / *i-bi*$_2$-*ẓi-kir* / i$_3$-na-sum / en / *i-bi*$_2$-*ẓi-kir* / *du-bi*$_2$ / *ḫa-ra-i*$_3$ / *a-*⌜*a*⌝*-da-*⌜*nu*⌝? / *maḫ-r*[*a*]*-da-m*[*u*] / *ḫa-b*[*a*] / *i-r*[*i*$_2$]*-ig*^{dingir}[*da*]-⌜*mu*⌝ / *ir*$_3$-*am*$_6$*-da-mu* / *iš*$_{11}$*-gi-ba-ir*$_3$ / *in-ma-lik* / *en-na-i*$_3$ / GABA-*da-mu* / *ri*$_2$-*i*$_3$*-ma-lik* / *en-na-ni-il* / *du-bi*$_2$-*ẓi-kir* / *ẓi-kir-ri*$_2$ / *ḫab*$_2$*-ra-ar* / *la*$_2$*-a-lum* / *u*$_3$*-ti* / *ib-gi* / *in* / *ur*$_2$*-lu*^{ki} / šu-ba$_4$-ti […]; "21 low quality embroidered cloaks, 10 tunics, those of the 'wool warehouse': expenditure; (and) 11 tunics, which (are from) the house of Ibbi-zikir, have been given (to):[16] the king, Ibbi-zikir, Dubi, Ḫara-i(l), A'⌜a⌝-da⌜nu⌝?, Maḫr[a]-dam[u], Ḫab[a], Ir[i]g-[da]-⌜mu⌝, Iram-

15. On the expression i$_3$-giš sag, see Viganò 2000. Bonechi recently observed (2020a, 113n56 with bibliography) that the "olive oil of the head" indicates a ritual cleaning following a period of mourning.
16. The 21 sets of garments suggest that the king should be included among the recipients.

damu, Išgi-bair, In-malik, Enna-i(l), GABA-damu, Ri'i-malik, Ennani-il, Dubi-zikir, Zikir-ri, Ḫabrar, La'a-lum, Uti, Ibgi,[17] in Urlu have been delivered […]".

Evidence suggests that in fact at least ten names originally included in *ARES* I do not refer to royal sons since they appear in passages such as the one quoted above.[18]

The remaining twenty-three royal sons who do not appear in the lists of dumu-nita en are documented elsewhere in the administrative record, sometimes with one (or two) other members of this social group:

> **[75.1781 = *M* 7 50]** obv.III:16-IV:4: 2 aktum^{tug_2} mu$_4^{mu}$ / 3 aktum^{tug_2} ti-TUG$_2$ / *ig-su-ub-da-mu* / *ib-ẓa-da-mu* / 2 dumu-nita / en; "2 tunics (for the) dressing,[19] 3 ribbed[20] tunics, (for) Igsub-damu (and) Ibza-damu, two royal sons".

It is not clear why only a third of the royal sons appear in the lists. But before diving into the main topic of this paper, a few remarks are in order on the data published in *ARES* I. In particular, new documents suggest that the total number of royal sons and the groups identified therein should be slightly reconsidered.

Of great importance for the study of the royal sons are the 'transition lists': these present royal sons belonging to different groups within the same document, thus establishing a strong synchronism between them. Only two such lists have been recognized so far. A first list mentioning royal sons from both Groups 1 and 2 was pointed out in *ARES* I ([75.2280]; Archi 1988a, 222). A second transition list published by Francesco Pomponio (2008, xx-xxi) further suggests that during the archaic period, the royal sons numbered at least eleven.[21] Six royal sons (four belonging to Group 1) appear in [75.1535 = *A* XV 26] together with five sons of a new 'Group 0'. This is the only list of royal sons and daughters available for this period (see also Table 2 below):

> **[75.1535 = *A* XV 26]** obv.VIII:9-IX:12: 5 aktum^{tug_2} / sag-*da-mu* / GABA-*da-mu* / tug$_2$-du$_8$-*da-mu* / *i-ti*-^{dingir}'*a*$_3$-*da* / *ig-ri*$_2$-*iš-da-mu* / 6 ḪAŠ zara$_6^{tug_2}$ / *i-ti-ni-ki-mu* / *ma-ḫa-ra-da-mu* / *a-ḫu-ma-i*$_3$-*lum* / *a-bur-da-si-in* / *i-in*-^{dingir}'*a*$_3$-*da* / gu$_4$-<*ra*>-*da-mu* / 5 tug$_2$-NI.NI sa$_6$ / *ti*-NE-*ib*$_2$-*da-mu* / *dag-mul*(MU:MU)-*mu-da-mu* / *dar-maš-da-mu* / *ma-u*$_3$-*ud* / *i-ti-mu-ud* / 3 ḪAŠ zara$_6^{tug_2}$ / *da-ti*-^{dingir}tu / *ẓa-ne-ma-ri*$_2$ / *da*$_5$-*ẓa-da-mu*; "5 tunics, (for royal sons) Sag-damu, GABA-damu, Tug$_2$-du$_8$-damu, I-ti-'Ada, Igriš-damu; 6 ḪAŠ zara$_6$ garments, (for royal sons) Iti-nikimu, Maḫara-damu, Aḫuma-ilum, Abur-dasin, I'in-'Ada, Gu<ra>-damu (=Šura-damu?); 5 NI.NI garments of good quality, (for royal

17. The persons mentioned in this passage belong to the elite: the king, his vizier, two royal sons (Maḫra-damu and Ḫaba), and several lords and/or abba$_2$ (Dubi, Ḫara-i(l), Irig-da-mu, Išgi-bair, In-malik, GABA-damu, Ri'i-malik, Ḫabrar, Uti) appear; some among them were also judges (Iram-damu, Ennani-il).
18. For a detailed list of the names and the texts in which they appear, see Scarpa 2021b.
19. On the meaning of mu$_4^{mu}$ at Ebla, see Pasquali 1996 and 1997, 251-253.
20. See Maiocchi 2019, 48.
21. Pomponio (2008, xx-xxi) counts 20 names appearing in five documents: [75.2165 = *A* XV 47] (quoted below), [75.10276 = *A* XV 59] obv.IX:1-11, [75.2246 = *A* XV 49] obv.XIII:8-17, [75.1843 = *A* XV 38] rev.IV:5-15, [75.1862 = *A* XV 36] rev.IX:1'-9'. The last four passages, however, most probably list female names of royal daughters.

daughters) TiNEib-damu, Dagmul-damu,[22] Darmaš-damu, Ma'ud, Iti-mud, 3 ḪAŠ zara$_6$ garments, (for) Dati-Tu, Zane-mari, Dabza-damu".

Although the terms dumu-nita and dumu-mi$_2$ en do not appear in this passage, almost all individuals occur elsewhere as royal sons or daughters. This document also possibly reveals two new names of royal sons (*a-ḫu-ma-i$_3$-lum*, *a-bur-da-si-in*). However, only a few of the royal sons mentioned in this list survive Irkab-damu's reign: four (GABA-*da-mu*, Tug$_2$-du$_8$-*da-mu*, *I-ti-*^{dingir}'*A$_3$-da*, *Ig-ri$_2$-iš-da-mu*) disappear from the record with the beginning of Iš'ar-damu's reign. An exception is Sag-*da-mu*, who we know died early in his childhood before Iš'ar-damu became king. MAT [75.2165 = *A* XV 47] records his death:[23]

[75.2165 = *A* XV 47] rev.V:16-VI:5: 1 *GU-ZI*$^{\text{tug}_2}$ 1 aktum$^{\text{tug}_2}$ 1 ib$_2$-III sa$_6$ gun$_3$ / 1 dib šu$_2$+ša ku$_3$-gi / ib$_2$-la$_2$ ku$_3$:bar$_6$ / 1 gir$_2$ mar-tu ku$_3$-gi / sag-*da-mu* / dumu-nita en / E$_2$×PAP; "1 wool garment, 1 tunic, 1 embroidered waistband of good quality, 1 decorative disk (of the value of) 20 (shekels of) gold, 1 silver ceremonial belt, 1 golden Amorite dagger, (for) royal son Sag-damu, (for his) funerary ceremony".

Likewise, *A-hu-ma-i$_3$-lum*, *A-bur-da-si-in*, and *I-in-*^{dingir}'*A$_3$-da* do not appear in later documents. It must also be stressed that the kings never appear in these lists. All documents published since 1988 confirm this statement: crown prince Ir'ag-damu often appears in the same documents with his [half$^?$-]brothers, but he is never included in the dumu-nita en lists. Likewise, Irkab-damu and Iš'ar-damu are never included in the lists, and their names barely appear in the administrative record before rising to the throne.

The data presented in *ARES* I suggested the presence of fifty royal sons; however, only one-third of them appear in the dumu-nita en lists identified by Archi. Furthermore, a careful examination of all available data suggests that a few lists included are spurious and refer to individuals who were not royal sons. As illustrated below, documents published after 1988 offer further insight on the group of royal sons.

2.2 New data on the royal sons

Studies published in the last three decades on the main events characterizing life at the court of Palace G offer new important data on the chronological sequence of the lists identified in *ARES* I. Furthermore, four lists of royal sons quoted therein have recently been published (Archi 2018a; Samir 2019), and a fifth dated to the archaic period has been identified ([75.1535 = *A* XV 26]).[24]

22. On this female personal name, see Bonechi 2016e, 19n65.
23. In a document dated to same period (ArruLUM's vizierate, which lasted approximately five years), he appears with his wet-nurse: [75.2161 = *A* XV 45] obv.VI:6-9: 1 tug$_2$-NI.NI / ga-du$_8$ / S[ag-*d*]*a-mu* / dumu-nita en; "1 NI.NI garment, (for) the wet-nurse of royal son Sag-damu".
24. In addition, five more fragmentary lists have also been published. See Scarpa 2021b, 74, for a detailed account.

Although most documents are still waiting for publication, all remaining dumu-nita en lists have been extensively quoted in *ARES* I.

The classification of the groups of royal sons starts from the dumu-nita en lists: however, it must also take into account all other occurrences concerning the royal sons. Single mentions and full lists are so deeply intertwined that they cannot be understood without each other. As just stated, the publication of new documents containing lists of dumu-nita en and the increased knowledge of the main events characterizing Ebla's history offer new evidence for reconsidering the chronology and classification of the royal sons lists. These can now be classified into three groups (see Table 2; see also Appendix for a complete list of documents):

- **Group 0**: (or Archaic group) occurs exclusively in [75.1535 = *A* XV 26], a transition list with five names (Sag-*da-mu* A, GABA-*da-mu*, Tug$_2$-du$_8$-*da-mu*, *I-ti*-^{dingir}'*A*$_3$-*da*, *Ig-ri*$_2$-*iš-da-mu*) followed by four more names belonging to Group 1 (*I-ti-ni-ki-mu*, *Ma-ḫa-ra-da-mu*, *I-in*-^{dingir}'*A*$_3$-*da*, Gu$_4$-<*ra*->*da-mu*). Two further names (*A-ḫu-ma-i*$_3$-*lum* and *A-bur-da-si-in*) do not occur elsewhere in the administrative record.
- **Group 1**: To this group belong thirteen lists which invariably present the names of *Maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *I-da-ni-ki-mu*, *I-in*-^{dingir}'*A*$_3$-*da*, *I*$_3$-*lum-a-ḫi*, and *Šu-ra-da-mu*. In a fourteenth list, *Šu-ra-da-mu*'s name is omitted. A further four lists also present the names of royal sons *Ar-wa* and *Zu*$_{(2)}$-*du*.
- **Group 2**: Twenty-three lists contain ten names of royal sons active in the later period (*Ḫa-ba*, *Iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *Ze*$_2$-*da-mu*, *Ga-du-um*, *Zi-ib*$_2$-*da-mu*, Sag-*da-mu* B, *Ib-te-da-mu*, *Ih*$_2$-*zi-da-mu*, NE-ḪAR-*da-mu*, *Ir-kab-ri*$_2$-*zu*$_2$).

A chronological sequence of Groups 1 and 2 can now be established on the basis of several studies carried out in the last three decades.[25] Table 3 offers a synoptic representation of this sequence; the most striking feature is the complete disappearance of the dumu-nita en lists referring to Group 1 after Ibrium's mandate comes to an end. By the same token, lists referring to Group 2 appear only in documents dated to Ibbi-zikir's time as a minister. As pointed out in the introduction, this accounting fiction does not reflect the royal sons' social reality; as shown in Table 4, some among the sons of Group 1 still appear in documents dated to Ibbi-zikir in which dumu-nita en lists of Group 2 are found. Some administrative change must have taken place during this turnover in the administration; Fig. 2 further shows how the two groups would be almost unrelated if these co-occurrences were not taken into account.[26] This network offers a visual representation of the royal sons' distribution in the administrative record, considering both dumu-nita en lists and other occurrences. Each node represents a royal son or a document, and each edge the occurrence of a name in a given tablet. Nodes corresponding to transition lists are outlined in black. Colors highlight densely connected clusters of nodes – *i.e.*, royal sons who often appear together and their related documents.

25. For a detailed list see below sub Appendix, 5.2 Chronological data.
26. The graph has been produced with Gephi (https://gephi.org). Full resolution image, data, and graph file are hosted on GitHub at the following link: https://github.com/erica-scarpa/all-the-kings-sons.

Group 0	Group 1	Group 2
sag-*da-mu* (A)		
GABA-*da-mu*		
tug$_2$-du$_8$-*da-mu*		
i-ti-^{dingir}*a$_3$-da*		
ig-ri$_2$-iš-da-mu		
	maḫ-ra-da-mu	
	i-da-ni-ki-mu	
	a-ḫu-ma-i$_3$-lum	
	a-bur-da-si-in	
	i$_3$-lum-a-ḫu	
	i-in-^{dingir}*a$_3$-da*	
	šu-ra-da-mu	
	ar-wa	
	zu$_{(2)}$-du	
	ḫa-ba	
		iḫ-su-ub-da-mu
		ze$_2$-da-mu
		ga-du-um
		zi-ib$_2$-da-mu
		sag-*da-mu* (B)
		ib-te-da-mu
		il$_2$-zi-da-mu
		NE-ḪAR-*da-mu*
		ir-kab-ri$_2$-zu$_2$

Table 2: New distribution of royal sons according to the dumu-nita en lists.

3. The lives of the royal sons

3.1 Early life

The ages of the royal sons and daughters are difficult to determine; in most cases, there are no clues suggesting whether they are infants, adolescents, or adults when they appear in a given document. Taking into consideration all the data available for a single individual, however, it is possible to plausibly evaluate their age at a given moment. Tonietti (2010, 75-79) suggested that royal daughter *Zu-ga*-LUM was fourteen by the time she appeared in the administrative record for the first time. By the same token, *Maḫ-ra-da-mu* is probably one of the most long-lived persons appearing in the archives. His name starts occurring in archaic documents; assuming he was born in the middle of ArruLUM's vizierate (Ar.3), he would have been sixteen in year Ib.14, when Iš'ar-damu married Tabur-damu;[27] in year I.Z. 12, when crown prince Ir'ag-damu married Ibbi-zikir's daughter Za'aše, he would have been thirty-two. He was still alive a few years before the city's destruction, since he appears in transition list [75.2280];[28] at that time, he would have been close to forty years old. As I

27. Biga 2016, 204.
28. See chronological data presented in Appendix.

shall demonstrate below, namesakes are extremely rare in the royal male line of descent; the existence of more than one royal son named *Maḫ-ra-da-mu* can thus be reasonably excluded.

Texts	**Names**
[75.2273 = *A* XX 16]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *i-ti-*dingir'*a*$_3$*-da*, sag-*da-mu* B?, *ib-te-da-mu*
[75.1778 = *A* IV 21]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, **i-da-ni-ki-mu*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*
[75.2280]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ga-du-um*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ib-te-da-mu, il*$_2$*-ẓi-da-mu,* NE-ḪAR-*da-mu*, *ir-kab-ri*$_2$*-zu*$_2$, *ḫa-ba*
[75.1743 = *A* XX 9]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, **i-da-ni-ki-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.2439]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*
[75.2276]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*
[75.2245]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, sag-*da-mu* B, *ib-te-da-mu*
[75.1775 = *M* 7 48]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ga-du-um*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.1903 = *A* XX 12]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.2622]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.2327+75.4203 = *A* XX 24]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.1777]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.5432 = *A* XII 952]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.2462]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.10182]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *šu-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.1221]	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*
[75.2243]	*i-da-ni-ki-mu*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*
[75.1781 = *M* 7 50]	**i-da-ni-ki-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*
[75.10127]	*i-da-ni-ki-mu*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*
[76.530 = *A* I 5 = *M* 5 10]	*šu-ra-da-mu*, *ẓe*$_2$*-da-mu*
[75.10201]	*šu-ra-da-mu*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*, *il*$_3$*-'a*$_3$*-ag-da-mu*
[75.4171 = *A* XII 59]	*šu-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*, sag-*da-mu* B, *ib-te-da-mu*, *il*$_2$*-ẓi-da-mu*,
[75.2240 = *A* XX 21]	*ar-wa*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*
[76.542 = *A* VIII 542 = *M* 5 22]	*ar-wa*, *iḫ-su-ub-da-mu*, *ga-du-um*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*, sag-*da-mu* B, *ib-te-da-mu*, *il*$_2$*-ẓi-da-mu*
[75.2331 = *A* XX 19]	*šu-ra-da-mu*, *ḫa-ba*, *ga-du-um*, *ẓi-ib*$_2$*-da-mu*, *il*$_3$*-'a*$_3$*-ag-da-mu*

Table 4: Co-occurrences in administrative documents of dumu-nita en lists of Group 2 with royal sons of Group 1. An asterisk (*) marks indirect mentions.

These reconstructions are useful and necessary as they compensate for the complete lack of a clear sex-age terminology. Unfortunately, the scribes of Great Archive L.2769 and Small Archive L.2712 did not adopt any clear sex-age designations, apart from the very generic terms guruš, dam, and dumu-mi$_2$/-nita. In most cases, these are loosely adopted even on personnel lists and food allotment accounts. Ebla scribes, in fact, used the same term (dumu-nita and dumu-mi$_2$) to describe an infant as well as an adult son or daughter; there is no trace in the documents of terms such as dumu-gaba ("newborn") or dumu-sag ("first-born child").[29] The only exception is the mention of childbirths. However, when a woman gives birth, the name of the child is not recorded:

29. The term dumu-sag appears in the bilingual lists (*VE* 270) with the glosses *bu*$_3$*-ga-lu* / *bu*$_3$*-gu*$_2$*-lu* / *bu*$_3$*-ga-ru*$_{12}$, probably related to Akk. *bukru* ("son, child"; see *CAD* B [1965], s.v., 309-310). However, it remains unattested in the administrative documents. See Conti 1990, 111, with bibliography; Kogan 2015, 80 and n233; Krebernik 2018, 175.

> **[75.2429 = *M* 12 36]** obv.XVI:5-16: šu$_2$+ša gin$_2$-DILMUN ku$_3$:bar$_6$ / 2 *BU-DI* / 8 gin$_2$-DILMUN ku$_3$:bar$_6$ / šu-bal-ak / 2 gin$_2$-DILMUN ku$_3$-gi / NU$_{11}$-za 2 sag-*SU*$_3$ / *ti-iš-te-da-mu* / dumu-mi$_2$ / en / *in* ud / dumu-nita / tu-da; «20 weighted shekels of silver (for) two toggle-pins, 8 weighted shekels of silver of the value of 2 weighted shekels of gold, (for) the plating of their two heads, (for) Tište-damu, royal daughter, when she delivered a son.»

The number of royal sons (and daughters) mentioned in the documents finds no parallel in the number of childbirths attested in the administrative record.[30] Less than a dozen births referring to royal children appear in the documents, compared to more than fifty between dumu-nita and dumu-mi$_2$ en who lived during the age of the archives. That being the case, the scribes of the archives did not register the births of royal children which took place over a period of three to four generations. A possible explanation is that several of these births did not take place in the Palace and therefore did not leave a trace in the bookkeeping system.[31] Whatever the reason, when royal children start appearing in the documents, we have absolutely no clue to their age as it is not possible to observe their lives starting from day one. In the case of royal offspring, all children most probably lived with the court's ladies until they reached sexual maturity; their existence remained hidden behind that of their mothers, sisters, and wet-nurses until the moment they actively became part of the administrative life.[32]

That some of the children lived with the court ladies seems to be confirmed by the fact that wet-nurses (ga-du$_8$) often appear among them: a few dam en were in fact not related to the king but rather women entrusted with the children's care.[33] In eighteenth century Mari, children spent the

30. The terms referring to childbirth are ša$_3$-zu ("midwife") and tu-da ("to give birth"). The former (see *VE* 581, ša$_3$-zu / *mu-li-du*, *mu-li-tum*, from **wld*, "to give birth") is almost exclusively attested in archaic documents (9 occurrences): it refers to the midwives who helped ladies *Dar*$_5$*-kab-du-lum*, *En-na-*^{dingir}Utu, and a woman named *Bu*$_3$*-su-ra-ad*, during childbirth. The term tu-da appears more frequently (31 occurrences): in five cases, it refers to childbirths taking place in foreign kingdoms (*i.e.*, [75.1591 = *A* I 8] rev.VIII:16-IX:4: 1 SAL $^{\text{tug}_2}$ 1 ib$_2$-III gun$_3$ / *i-i-bu*$_3$ / maškim / *ir*-NE / nig$_2$-mul-an / [dam] / en / *du-ub*^{ki} / tu-da; «1 SAL garment 1 embroidered waistband, (for) I'i-bu, IrNE's appointee, {for relating the news that} Dub king's [lady] has delivered {a child}»), while nineteen occurrences are linked to events taking place at Ebla. Some of these refer to births within the royal family, while others can be linked to the family of the viziers. Several are related to the same birth. The group of royal sons and daughters outnumbers significantly the total occurrences of childbirths attested in the administrative record.
31. In Old-Babylonian Mari, royal children probably left the Palace and travelled with their nurses (see discussion in Ziegler 1997, 51-52). Although there is no evidence suggesting that the same happened at Ebla, food allotment accountings from Small Archive L.2712 shed some light on this topic. [75.1273 = *A* IV 5] (quoted in note 11) registers a delivery for the crown prince's nurse who left the city. The context does not clarify if the child travelled with her, but documents from Small Archive L.2712 demonstrate that women of different ranks lived in the Palace but also moved to/from nearby cities. Several royal wives are often linked with centers outside the city (Tonietti 1989, 85-87), while the central administration differentiated female personnel between "residing" (al$_6$-tuš) in the city and "leaving [for the] city outskirts" (e$_3$ uru-bar) (see [75.350 = *A* IX 51]).
32. On this topic, see most recently Biga 2019, 9-11.
33. See, for example, [75.1263 = *A* XIX 2] obv.VI':3-7, where wet-nurses *Ab-a-du*, *Gi-sa-du*, and *Iš-lu-i*$_3$*-la* appear among the court ladies and the kings' daughters. On wet-nurses at Ebla, see Biga 2000.

first months after birth outside the Palace; their presence among women is reflected in the quantities of oil used in personal hygiene allotted to women.[34] Unfortunately, only ten documents of the Small Archive L.2712 deal with oil disbursement (*A* IX 74-84), and neither of these concerns women or people living close to them. Likewise, cereals disbursements do not directly indicate the presence of children or adolescents among the court ladies. Food allotment for high-ranking women seem to have been distributed according to rank; in [75.537 = *A* IX 44], the queen (= *Da-bur-da-mu*), *Taš-ma*$_2$*-da-mu*, and *En-na-*^{dingir}Utu receive double the quantity of barley compared to other women.[35] There is no evidence suggesting that food quantities for women were calculated taking into account the presence of unnamed children. As a result, no data concerning infants of royal lineage living in Palace G is currently available.

It must also be stressed that there is no evidence suggesting at which point in life the children received their names; although the naming practices within the royal family clearly hint at the presence of dynastic names (but only in the female line of descent), there is no trace left in the documents of naming rituals. Nele Ziegler observed that within Zimri-Lîm's family, male personal names were chosen among the male members of the paternal line of descent, and that dynastic names were probably assigned to a new member only after his predecessor passed away.[36] Ebla's situation appears different: the kings' names never appear twice, and the children do not receive their ancestors' names. The two parallel lists of Ebla's rulers, [74.120 = Archi, *ARES* I, 213] and [75.2628 = *A* VII 150], present a sequence of twenty-four names belonging to Eblaite kings which are never associated with other male members of the royal family. The only clear onomastic element shared among most male members of the family is *-da-mu*.[37] Despite the scarce information on the structure of the royal family and its members, especially during the reigns of Igriš-Ḫalab and his predecessors, it seems that the presence of namesakes among the royal sons was extremely rare, especially in comparison to the group of the court ladies.[38]

34. Ziegler 1997, 50-51.
35. *Taš-ma*$_2$*-da-mu* and *En-na-*^{dingir}Utu were wives of king Igriš-Ḫalab and Irkab-damu respectively, and two of the most influential and long-lived women inhabiting Palace G at the time this document was drafted. See Milano 1990, 336, and the data gathered in Table 14, 346.
36. Zigler 1997, 49-50. On naming practices at Mari, see Durand 1984, 133-135.
37. The term *da-mu* is now interpreted as "blood, lineage" (Krebernik 1988, 80 s.v. *da-mu*; Fronzaroli 1998, 112-113; Archi 2015b, 21-22). Note that Bonechi (1997, 480) suggested an extended meaning of the term, denoting "le groupe social qui avait été élargi grâce il des accords politiques qui allaient au delà de la consanguinité, donc «le groupe élargi aux alliés, frères de sang», et non au sens étroit, celui de «souche»." See also Catagnoti 2003, 231; Marchesi 2011, 182.
38. I am aware only of the case of royal sons Sag-*da-mu* A and Sag-*da-mu* B (Igriš-Ḫalab's and Iš'ar-damu's sons, respectively).

		ir-kab-ri₂-ẓu₂	NE-ḤAR-*da-mu*	*il₂-ẓi-da-mu*	*ib-te-da-mu*	sag-*da-mu* (B)	*ẓi-ib₂-da-mu*	*ga-du-um*	*ẓu₂-da-mu*	*ilᵢ-su-ub-da-mu*	*ḫa-ba*	*ẓa-a-da-mu*	*a-da-mu*	*ẓu₍₂₎-du*	*ar-wa*	*šu-ra-da-mu*	*i-in-ᵈa₃-da*	*i₃-hum-a-ḫu*	*i-da-ni-ki-mu*	*maḫ-ra-da-mu*	
Ibrium	75.1938															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1435 = *A* IV 13															[•]	•	•	•	•	
	75.1337 = *A* XIX 13											•?				?	•	•	•	•	
	75.1322+ = *A* XIX 8															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.2455															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1748															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1522												•?			?	•	•	•	•	
	75.10153															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1730 = *M* 7 34															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.2417															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1681= *A* IV 19 = *M* 7 24													•	•	•		•		•	
	75.2358													•	•	•		•		•	
	75.1731 =*A* XX 7 = *M* 7 35													•	•	•		•		•	
[no date]	75.1792															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1427															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.1706															•	•	•	•	•	
	75.2368													•	•	•	•	•	•	•	
	75.2520																•	•	•	•	
Ibbi-zikir	75.2438				•	•	•	•													
	75.1729	•	•	•	•	•															
	75.1436						•	•	•	•											
	75.10229	•	•	•																	
	75.1894						•	•	•	•											
	75.1446 = *A* IV 14				•	•	•	•	•	•											
	75.2335					•	•	•	•	•											
	75.10170			•	•	•	•	•	•	•											
	75.2275		•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•											
	75.2270			•	•	•	•	•	•	•											
	75.1255 = *A* IV 1		•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•											
	75.2328 = *A* XX 17			•	•		•	•		•	•										
	75.2280	•	•	•	•		•	•	•	•	•					•				•	
[no date]	75.1216	•	•	•	•	•	•	•		•											
	75.1252				•	•	•	•													
	75.2542			•	•	•	•	•	•	•											
	75.3762 = *A* III 688						•	•	•	•											
	75.2336	•	•	•	•	•		•		•											
	75.2250	•	•	•	•	•		•													
	76.525			•	•	•	•	•		•											
	76.532		•	•	•	•	[•]	•	•	•											
	76.533			•	•	•	•	•		•											
	76.542			•	•	•	•	•		•											

Table 3: Chronological sequence of the dumu-nita en lists. Note that PNs *za-a-da-mu* and *a-da-mu* both appear in place of *šu-ra-da-mu* in [75.1337 = *A* XIX 13] and [75.1522]

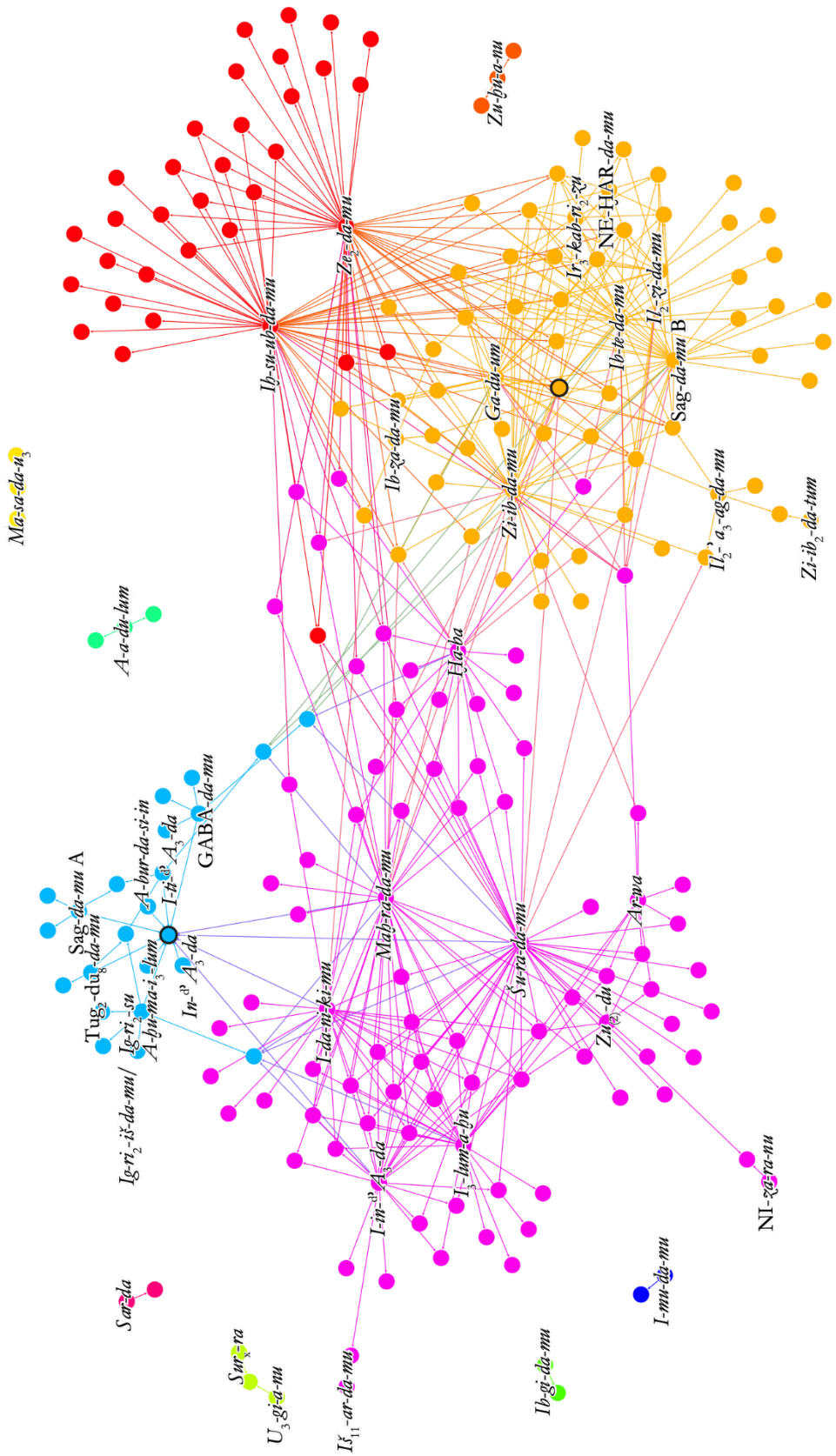

Fig. 2: Co-occurrence network of all the royal sons in the administrative record.

3.2 Adulthood

Data on royal sons' adulthood is similarly scarce. Interdynastic marriage is a well attested practice at Ebla, involving several among the royal daughters. Furthermore, non-Eblaite names borne by some royal wives suggest that some among them were high-ranking foreign women.[39] However, almost no trace is left in the administrative record concerning weddings involving the dumu-nita en.[40] Nevertheless, royal sons certainly got married and had offspring of their own: *I-da-ni-ki-mu* had at least five sons,[41] and *Ze$_2$-da-mu* at least one.[42] The almost complete absence of clues on weddings involving the male royal offspring certainly depends on how the administration digested the related economic transactions. The lexicon of marriage at Ebla consists of three terms: nig$_2$-(a$_2$-)de$_2$, bur-KAK (var. bur-NI), and nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$. The first two terms refer to the wedding ritual, during which the groom poured (nig$_2$-[a$_2$]-de$_2$) oil on the bride's head with a spouted jar (bur-KAK). The only occurrence known to me of a wedding ritual involving a royal son relates to this act:[43]

> **[75.2520]** obv.IX:1-13: *i-in-*^{dingir}'$_3$*-da* dumu-nita en nig$_2$-a-de$_3$ i$_3$-giš *a-li-iš iš-ru$_{12}$-ut* nin-ni *du-si-gu$_2$* e$_2$ AN.EN; "… royal son I'in-'Ada poured oil on (the head) of Išrut, Dusigu's sister, …".[44]

The last of the three terms represents a 'syllabic' local variant of Sumerian nig$_2$-mussa$_x$(SAL.US$_2$)$^{\text{sa}_2}$, literally "that which belongs to the son-in-law", *i.e.* 'bridewealth'.[45] At Ebla, the term appears most often in the expression *in* ud nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$; scholars generally translate it as "on the day of the wedding", but the phrase describes the moment of the bridewealth delivery by the groom's family. On this occasion, the scribes dutifully recorded the gifts for the bride, as well as 'counter-gifts' (nig$_2$-ba)

39. See PNs such as *su-na-im-ma-du* / *su-na-i$_3$-ma-du*. On Eblaite onomastics and non-Eblaite PNs, see Fronzaroli 1987; Edzard 1988; and Bonechi 1991. See also Steinkeller 1993 on Sumerian personal names attested in the Ebla archives.
40. See also Biga 2000, 61.
41. [75.1781 = *M* 7 50] obv.I:11-II:5: 1 '*a$_3$-da-um*$^{\text{tug}_2}$-II 1 aktum$^{\text{tug}_2}$ 1 ib$_2$+III$^{\text{tug}_2}$ sa$_6$ gun$_3$ / 4 '*a$_3$-da-um*$^{\text{tug}_2}$-I 4 aktum$^{\text{tug}_2}$ / 5 dumu-nita / *i-da-ni-ki-mu* / dumu-nita / en; "1 cloak, 1 tunic, 1 embroidered waistband of good quality; 4 cloaks, 4 tunics, (for) royal son Ida-nikimu's five sons". We also know that one of his sons' names was *Ir$_3$-da-ma-lik*: [75.1778 = *A* IV 21] obv.IV:13-V:2: 1 '*a$_3$-da-um*$^{\text{tug}_2}$-II 1 aktum$^{\text{tug}_2}$ 1 ib$_2$-III$^{\text{tug}_2}$ sa$_6$ / *ir$_3$-da-ma-lik* / 1 dumu-nita / *i-da-ne-ki-mu* / dumu-nita en; "1 cloak, 1 tunic, 1 good quality waistband, (for) Irda-malik, child of royal son Ida-nekimu".
42. See [75.341 = *A* IX 50] obv.II:3-4 discussed below.
43. Reference to another marriage appears in unpublished document [75.2332] obv.V:2-14: *zu$_2$-du* dumu-nita en nig$_2$-a-de$_3$ i$_3$-giš *a-li-iš* sag *ar-za-du* dumu-mi$_2$ en; "… royal son Zudu, (who) poured oil on royal daughter 'Arzatu's head" (quoted in Archi 2002a, 163n8). This unusual mention of a marriage between two royal children finds no parallel in other documents.
44. Quoted in Archi 2012, 15. The precise meaning of e$_2$ AN.EN in this context has not yet been ascertained. Scholars' opinions diverge on the interpretation of AN.EN(.KI); the term indicates a royal cemetery, according to Pasquali (2009; "l'endroit des rois défunts", ^{dingir}en$^{(\text{ki})}$; see more recently Pasquali 2016). However, in onomastics, it certainly represents the Sumerian spelling for the name of god Ḥayya (Tonietti 2011; Milano – Tonietti 2012, 47; see also Archi 2010b).
45. Stol 2016, 112. Sumerian mussa$_x$ is the term the family of the bride uses to address the husband (Wilcke 2003, 60-61). On the reading, see Steinkeller 1992, 36-37. On the lexicon for bridewealth in Sumerian and other ancient Semitic languages, see Greengus 1990, esp. 61-65.

for the involved families.[46] Contrary to the Old-Babylonian *terḫatum*,[47] which mainly consisted of silver, the nig$_2$-mussa$_{(x)}$ was made up of cattle and foodstuff. Eblaite bridewealths align well with the Sumerian tradition since they can be associated with cattle incomes. Palace G administration registered the nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$ as an income (mu-ku$_x$[DU]) of cattle, as in the case of royal daughter Kešdut's nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$:[48]

> **[75.2283 = EST 001]** rev.II^{ll}:1-5: šu-nigin$_2$ 3 *li-im* 2 *mi-at* 90 gu$_2$ / mu-ku$_x$(DU) / nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$ / *keš$_2$-du-ud* / dumu-mi$_2$ en; "Total: 3290 oxen, income: bridewealth (for) royal daughter Kešdut".

In the case of a wedding involving a royal son, the nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$ (*i.e.*, cattle) was delivered *by* the Palace administration *to* the family of the bride; however, no document concerning a similar expenditure has been published so far. Unpublished cereal, oil, and livestock accounts from the Trapezoidal Archive L.2764 will hopefully shed light on this particular issue.[49]

Whether the royal sons permanently lived at court or left the palace at a certain point in their lives is also difficult to ascertain. The food allotment documents of Small Archive L.2712 describe at length the cereals disbursement for the court ladies; those concerning the male inhabitants of the court do not present the same level of detail. It can be hypothesized that adult sons living in Palace G were part of the group appearing in the documents as e$_2$ en ("house of the king"); the high representatives of the chief families (abba$_2$) and several adult males (guruš) belonged to it, and the group probably counted up to two hundred individuals.[50] Royal sons sporadically appear in the food allotment documents of Small Archive L.2712, as in [75.276 = *A* IX 49]:

> **[75.276 = *A* IX 49]** obv.I:1-rev.II:3: 16 dam / ku$_2$ / ¼ še *BAR* / 4 še *BAR* / 34 dam / ku$_2$ / 1 GIN$_2$ / 6-½ še *BAR* 6 nig$_2$-sagšu / ¼ še <*BAR*> / ^{dingir}KU-*ra* / 15 dumu-nita / 3-½-¼ še *BAR* / ku$_2$ / dumu-nita en / iti še-gur$_{10}$-ku$_5$ / *ab*-NE / i$_3$-na-sum; "16 women: food (allotment is) ¼ *KUBĀRUM* of barley (*pro capite*), 4

46. See, for example, [75.1690 = *A* VII 117]. On the different steps involved in a marriage agreement, see Bonechi 2016a, 54.
47. See Dalley 1980, 54-55; Milano 1987. On bridewealth in Sumerian Ur III sources, see Lafont – Beckman 2003, 203.
48. See also how royal daughter *Zi-mi-ni*-ku$_3$:bar$_6$'s bridewealth is registered as an income from Burman: [75.1793] obv.III:15-IV:12: 1 zara$_6^{tug_2}$ 2 *BU-DI* ḪAŠ ku$_3$:bar$_6$ lu$_2$ *bur-ma-an^{ki}* mu-ku$_x$(DU) *in* ud nig$_2$-mu-sa$_2$ *zi-mi-ni*-ku$_3$:bar$_6$ *wa* in-na-sum *du-si-gu$_2$ di-rin$_x$*(ERIN)-*da-mu* 1 SAL^{tug_2} 1 ib$_2$+III-gun$_3^{tug_2}$ NE-*zi-ma-ḫu* e-gi$_4$ maškim *zi-mi-ni*-ku$_3$:bar$_6$ *MA-LIK-TUM bur-ma-an^{ki}*; "1 zara$_6$ garment, 2 ḪAŠ toggle-pins, (those for the) income of (= from) Burman on the occasion of the bridewealth (payment), (for) Zimini-ku$_3$:bar$_6$; and … Dusigu, Dirin-damu; 1 SAL garment, 1 embroidered waistband (for) NEzim(-a)ḫu, envoy of Zimini-ku$_3$:bar$_6$, queen of Burman". Quoted in Biga 1996, 68. See also Fronzaroli 2003, 79.
49. For a brief description of the Trapezoidal Archive L.2764, see Biga 1988, 300-304.
50. See Milano 1990, 333. The entry 'e$_2$ en' appears, for example, in [75.228 = *A* IX 1], [75.247 = *A* IX 2], and [75.538 = *A* IX 3]. These documents list food allotment for the 'king's house' (e$_2$ en), several groups of women (dam, dam *bu$_3$-zu-ga^{ki}*), and other personnel (ib-ib, a-am, u$_2$-a). Accounts referring exclusively to the group defined as e$_2$ en (such as [75.266 = *A* IX 10], [75.445 = *A* IX 12], [75.229 = *A* IX 13]) tell us that it comprised the king, the high representatives of the chief families (abba$_2$), KUra and the gods of the city outskirts (^{dingir}KU-*ra wa* dingir-dingir-dingir), and other adult males (guruš-guruš).

KUBĀRUM of barley (in total); 34 women: food (allotment is) 1 GIN_2 of barley (*pro capite*), 6-½ *KUBĀRUM* and 6 nig_2-sagšu of barley (in total); ¼ <*KUBĀRUM*> of barley (is for) KUra; 15 sons: 3-½-¼ *KUBĀRUM* of barley (in total is the) food (allotment for the) royal sons. Month II. AbNE has given".

In [75.341 = *A* IX 50] the scribe further calculates the monthly food allotment for fourteen members of the royal family: 5-½ *KUBĀRUM* for seven sons and seven daughters (8 nig_2-sagšu *pro capite*), and 12-¼ *KUBĀRUM* for forty-nine court ladies. The seven royal sons were *Ih₂-ẓi-da-mu*, *Ne-a-la-da-mu* (= NE-ḪAR-*da-mu*), and *Ir₃-kab-ri₂-ẓu* of Group 2, *Ib-ẓa-da-mu*,[51] two young royal sons (dumu-nita tur),[52] and *Ze₂-da-mu*'s son (Group 2). No other royal son appears in the food allotment of Small Archive L.2712, with the exception of crown prince Ir'ag-damu (see below). It must be stressed, however, that the documents of Small Archive L.2712 date to the very last years before Ebla's final destruction. Since neither the royal sons of Group 1 nor their close families (wives, children) appear therein, it can be reasonably assumed that they were not living in the Palace. However, as I shall demonstrate below, royal sons of Group 1 were still significantly involved in the Palace's political endeavors under minister Ibbi-zikir.

Royal sons also appear in the "Ebla official cult texts";[53] these accounts list sheep delivered on the occasion of cultic celebrations. The animals were sacrificed to different gods according to a very dense cultic calendar.[54] Several royal sons appear in these documents: [75.1764 = *M* 7 44] lists a group of unnamed royal sons, Sag-damu B, and two more offerings on behalf of a group of unnamed royal sons; [75.2238 = *M* 12 26] lists *Iḫ-su-ub-da-mu* (= *Ig-su-ub-da-mu*, mentioned twice), *Ze₂-da-mu*, *Zi-ib₂-da-mu*, Sag-*da-mu* B, and a group of dumu-nita tur;[55] finally, [75.11010 = *M* 12 41] simply mentions the royal sons as a group (dumu-nita dumu-nita en). These documents prove that the royal sons of Group 2 participated in the cultic activities involving the most important members of the royal family: the king (Iš'ar-damu), the queen (Tabur-damu), princess Kešdut, crown prince Ir'ag-damu, and his wife (Za'aše, who was also Ibbi-zikir's daughter). Like cereal allotment documents, all official cult texts date to the years before Ebla's fall; whether this cultic function was performed by the sons of Group 1 in earlier years can be argued, but not proved. None of the available evidence shows the sons of Group 1 involved in such cultic duties.

The interpretation of the evidence presented so far partially accounts for the gap between the sons of Groups 1 and 2 shown in Table 3. This gap most probably reflects a corresponding division of duties; in fact, although they occasionally appear in the same documents, the two groups of dumu-nita

51. He is a royal son who never appears in the dumu-nita en lists: [75.1781 = *M* 7 50] obv.III:15-IV:4: 2 $aktum^{tug_2}$ mu_4^{mu} / 3 $aktum^{tug_2}$ ti-TUG_2 / *ig-su-ub-da-mu* / *ib-ẓa-da-mu* / 2 dumu-nita / en; "2 tunics, (for) the dressing, 3 ribbed tunics, (for) Igsub-damu, Ibza-damu, two royal sons". On these royal sons see also Bonechi 1997, 481 n. 30.
52. For the interpretation of dumu-nita tur as "grandson", see Biga 2019, 11.
53. On this textual category, see the précis in Tonietti 2016, 65 n. 4. Further data has been published by Archi 2017, esp. 294, Table 1. There are 23 documents belonging to this category, of which only four have been published (Pettinato 1979). All date to the last years before the destruction of the city. See also Milano – Tonietti 2012, 35-37.
54. See Archi 2017, 300, Table 4.
55. Groups of dumu-nita en maḫ and tur sporadically appear in archaic documents (such as [75.1567 = *A* XV 29] rev.IX:3-8: 10 siki na_4 / nig_2-bar-DU / dumu-nita dumu-mi_2 maḫ en / 10 siki na_4 / nig_2-la_2-gir_7 / dumu-nita dumu-mi_2 tur). However, the scribes of the archives do not consistently adopt the pair of adjectives as an age designation.

en are almost never involved in the same activities. There are, in fact, several elements connecting royal sons of Group 1 to different social functions. [75.2331 = *A* XX 19], quoted below, establishes a clear connection between the royal sons and one of Ebla's most important social groups: the lords (lugal).

> **[75.2331 = *A* XX 19]** rev.XI:13-XII:3: 10 ʾ*a*$_3$-*da-um*^{tug2}-II 10 aktum^{tug2} 10 ib$_2$-I^{tug2} sa$_6$ gun$_3$ / *ḫa-ba* / *šu-ra-da-mu* / *i-ri*$_2$-*ik-da-mu* / *ir*$_3$-*am*$_6$-*da-mu* / *in-ma-lik* / GABA-*da-mu* / [*ir*$_3$]-*i*$_3$-*ba* / *iš*$_{11}$-*ga-*<*ba*>-*ir*$_3$ / *u*$_3$-*ti* / *na-ẓu-mu* / abba$_2$; "10 cloaks, 10 tunics, 10 embroidered waistbands of good quality, (for) Ḫaba (royal son), Šura-damu (royal son), Irik-damu (Ibrium's son and lord), Iram-damu (lord and judge), In-malik (Ibrium's son and/or lord), GABA-damu (lord),[56] [Ir]'i-ba (lord), Išga-<ba>ir (lord), Uti (Ibrium's son and lord), Nazumu,[57] the high representatives".

Eight of the ten men quoted in this passage appear in the so-called mu-ku$_x$(DU) documents concerning incomes of metals to the central administration.[58] As previously stated, royal sons do not appear exclusively in the dumu-nita en lists; as a rule of thumb, we can assume that the remaining occurrences most likely refer to them although they are not always qualified as royal sons. As previously stated, namesakes are rare in the male line of descent, and the scribes pointed out non-royal namesakes by stating their patronymic, place of provenance, or profession.[59] A similar passage mentions royal sons and lords together:

> **[75.1903 = *A* XX 12]** rev.I:7$^{!!}$-II:9: 10[+6 …] / 10[+6] i[b$_2$-III^{tug2}] s[a$_6$ gun$_3$] / ⌜ʾ*a*$_3$⌝$^?$-[x]-L[UM] / ⌜x⌝[-x]-⌜x⌝-[x]$^?$ / *du-b*[*i*$_2$-x] / *ḫa-ra-i*$_3$ / *a-mur-da-mu* / *maḫ-ra-da-mu* / *ḫa-ba* / *nab-ḫa-*⌜*i*$_3$⌝ / *šu-ra-da-mu* / *ir*$_3$-*am*$_6$-*ma-lik* / *iš*$_{11}$-*gi-bar-ẓu*$_2$ / *en-na-i*$_3$ / *in-ma-lik* / *i-bi*$_2$-*šum* / *ir*$_3$-*i*$_2$-*ba* / ⌜*i*⌝-*ri*$_2$-*ik*-[*d*]*a-mu* / ⌜x-x⌝-[…]; "10[+6] […] 10[+6] [embroidered waist]bands of go[od quality], (for) ⌜ʾA⌝$^?$-[x]-L[UM], ⌜x⌝[-x]-⌜x⌝-[x]$^?$, Dub[i-x], Ḫara-i(l) (lord), Amur-damu (lord, maybe also Ibrium's grandson)[60], Maḫra-damu (royal son), Ḫaba (royal son), Nabḫa-⌜i(l)⌝ (lord and Ibrium's son), Šura-damu (royal son), Iram-malik (lord),

56. This man is probably a namesake of the royal son belonging to Group 0. This would, in fact, be the only occurrence of GABA-*da-mu* dumu-nita en not dated to ArruLUM's time as a minister.
57. A man named *Na-ẓu-mu* appears as an abba$_2$ also in [75.1328 = *A* XIX 11] obv.III:11-IV:5: 3 gu-mug^{tug_2} 3 SAL-tug$_2$ 3 ib$_2$×IV gun$_3$^{tug_2} / ʾ*a*$_3$-*da-rum*$_2$ / *na-ẓu-mu* / *i-du-lu* / abba$_2$-abba$_2$. Furthermore, the son of a man named Nazumu appears in both versions of the Ebla Royal Ritual (Fronzaroli 1993).
58. For a detailed prosopography of the lords, see Archi 2000; on judges at Ebla, see Catagnoti 2003, 230 and Archi – Biga – Milano 1988, 263-265. Note that three more royal sons appear in this document: [75.2331 = *A* XX 19] rev.IV:10-21: 2 aktum^{tug_2} / *ga-du-um* / *ẓi-ib*$_2$-*da-mu* / 2 dumu-nita / en / 1 zara$_6$^{tug_2} u$_2$-ḫab$_2$ / nig$_2$-ba / *il*$_2$-ʾ*a*$_3$-*ak-da-mu* / ^{dingir}ʾ*a*$_5$-*da-bal* / *lu-ba-an* / *in* / ne-sag; "2 tunics, (for) Gadum, Zi'ib-damu, two royal sons; 11 dark red zara$_6$ garment, gift (from$^?$) Ir'ag-damu (to$^?$) Hadda-ba'al of Luban on the occasion of the ne-sag offerings".
59. One *I-da-ni-ki-mu* was certainly a priest (lu$_2$ dingir-dingir-dingir, "man of the gods"$^?$; see [75.5474 = *A* XII 991]); one *I-de*$_3$-*ne-ki-mu* was a dancer (NE.DI; [75.5306 = *A* XII 868], obv.I':1'-8'). See also Benati – Bonechi 2020, 42; Bonechi 2016d, 13-14.
60. One *A-mur-da-mu* appears in the administrative record as dumu-nita *Nab-ḫa-i*$_3$/*Nab-ḫa-il*, who was Ibrium's son. See, for example, [75.3850 = *A* III 762] obv.$^?$II':2'-7': [N] dib / *nab-ḫa-i*$_3$ / *wa* / i$_3$-na-sum / *a-mur-da-mu* / dumu-nita-*SU*$_3$.

Išgi-barzu (lord), Enna-i(l), In-malik (Ibrium's son and/or lord), Ibišum (lord), Ir'i-ba (lord) Ṭ'rik-[d]amu (lugal), ˹x-x˺-[…]".

Although partially broken, this passage presents a further link between the royal sons and the lords. In [75.2331 = *A* XX 19], the ten men are called abba$_2$: the scribes of the Archives most often used this term to refer to the foreign retinues of high-ranking individuals who visited Palace G following their kings. This link suggests the tantalizing hypothesis that Eblaite royal sons visited neighboring territories as Ebla's representatives together with other Eblaite high-ranking officials. In addition, the same *Na-ẓu-mu* mentioned in [75.2331 = *A* XX 19] together with two royal sons was a prominent figure; he travelled to Armi with judge *Iš-ma$_2$-da-mu* to resolve a border conflict between Ebla and Armi.[61]

However, the broader contexts of these two passages further connect documents [75.2331 = *A* XX 19] and [75.1903 = *A* XX 12]; in both tablets, the two transactions belong to a series of huge disbursements of garments for personnel teams (*ir$_3$-a-num$_2$*). In [75.1903 = *A* XX 12], garments and wool are delivered to adult males (guruš) and other professional categories as part of an established allowance for the city of Adin (igi-ḫi-du$_8$ *A-ti-nu*^{ki}).[62]

A link between the royal sons of Group 1 and the lords recurs also in [75.1775 = *M* 7 48] (quoted above); however, no self-evident element links this transaction to a particular circumstance or event.[63]

3.2.1 *The crown prince*

Another important element that emerges from the record is that crown prince Ir'ag-damu enjoyed a different status with respect to other royal sons. Last in the line of descent, his prominence among the royal children hints at the possibility that he was meant to succeed his father. There are at least two elements corroborating this assertion. The first is the fact that he is never mentioned together with other royal sons. Together with his sister Kešdut, he is the only royal child who appears both

61. *Na-ẓu-mu* does not belong to the group of the lords but certainly is an interesting individual: he appears in a series of documents concerning a border dispute between Ebla and Armi which took place later in Ibbi-zikir's mandate. On this occasion, *Na-ẓu-mu* leaves for Armi together with judge *Iš$_2$-ma$_2$-da-mu* and a travel allowance of twenty shekels, an expenditure accounted for in the AAM dated to that period: [75.2428 = *M* 12 35] obv.XIII:3-13: ša-pi gin$_2$-DILMUN ku$_3$:bar$_6$ / nig$_2$-kaskal / *na-ẓu-mu* / *iš-ma$_2$-da-mu* / DU.DU / *si-in* / *ar-mi*^{ki} / di-ku$_5$ / *al$_6$* / uru^{ki}-uru^{ki} / *ib-la*^{ki}; "40 weighted shekels of silver (*i.e.* 20 *pro capite*), (is) the travel allowance (for) Nazumu (and) Išma-damu, (who) went to Armi (for) the rendering (of a verdict) concerning Ebla's villages". The dossier regarding the border dispute between Ebla and Armi has been studied in detail by Bonechi 2016c. For further considerations on the synchronism between these documents by the same author, see Bonechi 2020a.
62. [75.1903 = *A* XX 12] rev.VI:15-16. For a different interpretation of igi-ḫi-du$_8$, see Archi 2018b. I follow here the most commonly accepted interpretation of the term, based on gloss *VE* 711 igi-ḫi-du$_8$ / *mu-ša-gu-um* > /mūṯaqu/, from **wṯq* (*DRS* 7 [1997], 660), "spettanza stabilita" (Fronzaroli 1988, 18). Archi (2018b) suggests instead the meaning "review; to pass in review": the term refers in his opinion to an inspection on the occasion of a military expedition (see also Archi 2018a, 86). The historical implications of either interpretations are not clear to me. See also Bonechi 2020b, 327 and n. 24.
63. The persons mentioned in this passage belong to the elite: the king, his vizier, two royal sons (*maḫ-ra-da-mu* and *ḫa-ba*), and several lords and/or abba$_2$ (*du-bi$_2$*, *ḫa-ra-i$_3$*, *i-ri$_2$-ig-*^{dingir}*da-mu*, *iš$_{11}$-gi-ba-ir$_3$*, *in-ma-lik*, GABA-*da-mu*, *ri$_2$-i$_3$-ma-lik*, *ḫab$_2$-ra-ar*, *u$_3$-ti*) appear; some among them were also judges (*ir$_3$-am$_6$-da-mu*, *en-na-ni-il*).

as the king's and the queen's son. A possible explanation is thus that Ir'ag-damu was the royal couple's son, a circumstance which cannot be demonstrated for any other man mentioned in the archives. Likewise, his father Iš'ar-damu and his grandfather Irkab-damu never appear among other royal sons; however, Iš'ar-damu was certainly not the royal couple's son.[64] It seems, however, that Ir'ag-damu's status differed from that of his predecessors: although both Irkab-Damu and Iš'ar-damu are never mentioned in the dumu-nita en lists, neither of them appears in the administrative record before rising to the throne. The only common feature that can be safely identified is the fact that the kings of Ebla enjoyed a particular status before their nomination, but it does not seem that this depended on the fact that they were born from the royal couple.

Second, as stated above, Ir'ag-damu often appears with the king, the queen, and his brothers in the official cult texts. He appears in the record with his wife Za'aše, who was also vizier Ibbi-zikir's daughter. Data concerning the wedding between the crown prince and Za'aše brings further insight on the marriages involving the royal sons. [75.1699 = *A* VII 132] mentions Za'aše's bridewealth, while counter-gifts are recorded in [75.1690 = *A* VII 117]. The wedding involving Za'aše is closely linked to the city of Dara'um, where her ancestral home was located;[65] similarly, queen Tabur-damu's ancestral home was not Ebla, despite her name belonging to the royal family's name-giving tradition.[66] The evidence here presented demonstrates that weddings involving Eblaite high-ranking men generally took place at Ebla, regardless of the bride's provenance; however, from an accounting perspective, the focus of the wedding ritual is always on the bride, while little reference is made to the groom and his family. As a consequence, the lack of evidence concerning the royal sons' weddings is not surprising. Nevertheless, Ir'ag-damu's marital situation is that typical of other high-ranking men: he had one main wife, Za'aše,[67] and possibly six secondary wives.[68] Za'aše also probably had a child once married to the crown prince, as she appears with a wet-nurse in [75.3168 = *A* III 144].[69] Furthermore, Ir'ag-damu's six secondary wives lived at court since they appear in

64. His mother Dusigu often appears among the court ladies and bears the title of ama-gal en ("mother of the king"); however, she never bore the title of *MA-LIK-TUM*. On her role at court, see Biga 2016.
65. See Bonechi 2016b, 35 n. 97.
66. Adding weight to this interpretation is a passage concerning an omen: [75.2417] obv.VII:6-18 1 *'a$_3$-da-um*^{tug_2} 1 ib$_2$+III^{tug_2} sa$_6$ gun$_3$ / *ti-ti-nu* / maškim *ib-ri$_2$-um* / nig$_2$-mul-an / ama-gal / en / maš$_2$ sa$_6$ / lu$_2$ dingir a-mu / *da-bur-da-mu* / *MA-LIK-TUM* / *ib-la*^{ki}; "1 cloak, 1 embroidered waistband of good quality, for Titinu, Ibrium's appointee, (for bringing) the news (to) the king's mother (concerning) the favorable omen of the god of the father of Tabur-damu, (who will be) queen of Ebla". See Bonechi 2016a, 54 and n11, with bibliography. For a different interpretation, see Biga 1999; note that Biga 2016, 204, has suggested that Iš'ar-damu and Tabur-damu were cousins. See also Biga – Capomacchia 2012, 21.
67. It must also be noted that a difficult passage from an unpublished document refers to *Za-a-še$_3$* as *MA-LIK-TUM*: [75.12436] II:1-9: 2 bracelets *in* nig$_2$-mu-sa$_{10}$ (*sic*!) bur-KAK *za-a-še MA-LIK-TUM ib-la*^{ki}. The context is not clear. See Archi 2015a, 169 n. 21.
68. At least three documents from Small Archive L.2712 mention six women connected to Ir'ag-damu ([75.302 = *A* IX 36], obv.II:6-7; [75.236 = *A* IX 37] obv.VI:2-6; [75.241 = *A* IX 38] rev.III:1-7). Their names are: *ḫa-lu-du*, *ti-gi*-^{dingir}utu, *da-ti*-^{dingir}*gu$_2$-ša*, *ma-nu*-SAL-NI-DU / *ma-nu-ki*-mul, *iš-da-ma$_2$*-^{dingir}KU-*ra*, *si-na-ma-lik*. Note, however, that the term might refer to female adult servants rather than wives. Nevertheless, the fact that they are mentioned by name (and not simply as dam *Ir$_3$-'a$_3$-ag-da-mu*) suggests they enjoyed a certain status.
69. [75.3168 = *A* III 144] obv.? III':1'-9': 2 […] / 3 x-[…] / 4 ga-du$_8$ / 4 dumu-nita / en / GAL.TUM / *wa* / ga-du$_8$ / *za-a-še$_3$*.

food allotment accounts among other court ladies. As with other royal sons, Ir'ag-damu himself rarely appears in the documents of the Small Archive L.2712.

4. Conclusions

The data here presented on the dumu-nita en coupled with the research conducted on Ebla and its society in the last four decades allows for drawing a few significant conclusions. A first important finding regards naming practices: there are no namesakes in the male royal line of descent. With the sole exception of Sag-damu A and B, all other royal sons bore different names. This conclusion has important repercussions on the study of the royal family's genealogy; in the absence of data on paternity and maternity, it establishes a solid ground on which to investigate royal sons' membership to a given step in the line of descent.

The recognition that there are no namesakes among the royal sons also facilitates the quantification, albeit hypothetical, of life ranges as in the case of Maḫra-damu. These estimates, although in most cases artificial, offer plausible (or implausible) scenarios; a careful comparison of these evaluations with those referring to other members of the royal family will offer a more detailed socio-historical picture of the royal family and the family of the viziers.

Evidence shown in section 3.2 (Adulthood) suggests that most royal sons either did not live at court or were not accounted for with this role in the food allotment texts. Although most dumu-nita en do not appear in the documents of Small Archive 2712, some of them could be part of the "house of the king" (e_2 en). This interpretation implies, in my opinion, that they were adults; children were most probably accounted as a group with the court ladies.[70] Royal sons of Group 1 seem to be involved in political and diplomatic activities together with high-ranking functionaries; they certainly did not carry out duties comparable to the viziers', and they do not seem to enjoy a particular status with respect to either Ibbi-zikir or Dubuḫu-'Ada. In fact, they do not appear in the diplomatic correspondence; the recently published letters found in vestibule L.2875 (Catagnoti – Fronzaroli 2020) confirm this statement. By the same token, they are also absent from unpublished documents from Trapezoidal Archive L.2875.[71]

Royal sons of Group 2 were instead consistently involved in cultic activities, as accounts of sheep for offerings demonstrate. The reason for this clear subdivision of duties is difficult to identify and, although apparently connected to age, could also have different motivations. Further investigations on the other members of Ebla's two most important families will certainly make clear the royal sons' position at court.

70. See, for example, [75.276 = *A* IX 49] quoted above.
71. See the prosopography published in Archi – Biga – Milano 1988, 293-299.

5. Appendix

5.1 Lists of royal sons

5.1.1. *Group 0 (Archaic group)*

- [75.1535 = *A* XV 26] obv.VIII:15-IX:12;

5.1.2 *Group 1*

- [75.1322 = *A* XIX 8] rev.I:18-II:10
- [75.1337 = *A* XIX 13] rev.V:16-VI:8
- [75.1427] obv.X:9-14
- [75.1435 = *A* IV 13] obv.XII:14-18
- [75.1522] rev.IV:1-6
- [75.1681 = *A* IV 19 = *M* 7 24] rev.III:14-IV:8
- [75.1706] rev.V:5-11
- [75.1730 = *M* 7 34] rev.XII:11"-XIII:16
- [75.1731+75.2498 = *A* XX 7 (= *M* 7 35)] obv.IV:21-V:8[72]
- [75.1748] rev.III:14-IV:3
- [75.1792] rev.III:7-12
- [75.1938] rev.II:1'-6'
- [75.2358] obv.III:10-16
- [75.2368] obv.V:1-9
- [75.2417] rev.IX:7-X:3
- [75.2455] obv.IX:7-12
- [75.2520] obv.IX:15-X:5
- [75.10153] obv.VII:9-X:2

5.1.3 *Group 2*

- [75.1216] obv.I:2-II:3
- [75.1252] rev.III:25-14 (*sic*!)
- [75.1255 = *A* IV 1] obv.I:16-21
- [75.1255 = *A* IV 1] obv.VIII:14-23
- [75.1436] obv.I:4-9
- [75.1446 = *A* IV 14] obv.I:1-III:10
- [75.1729] rev.VII:3-20
- [75.1894] obv.I:14-II:5
- [75.2250] obv.V:23-VI:8
- [75.2270] obv.IX:11-18
- [75.2275] obv.I:2-III:9

72. Note that the edition in *M* 7 35 refers exclusively to 75.1731. For the join with 75.2498, see *A* XX 7.

- [75.2280] obv.VII:8-VIII:11
- [75.2280] obv.X:2-6
- [75.2328 = *A* XX 17] obv.VII:7-IX:8
- [75.2335] obv.XI:24-XII:3
- [75.2336] obv.VIII:10'-IX:22
- [75.2438] obv.II:14-19
- [75.2542] obv.III:9-15
- [75.3762 = *A* III 688] rev.I:5'-9'
- [75.10170] obv.II:2-rev.I:5
- [75.10229] obv.VIII:19-IX:4
- [76.525 = *A* VIII 525 = *M* 5 5] obv.VII:10-19
- [76.532 = *A* VIII 532 = *M* 5 12] obv.I:1-II:10
- [76.533 = *A* VIII 533 = *M* 5 13] rev.VI:14-23
- [76.542 = *A* VIII 542 = *M* 5 22] obv.IX:14-24

5.2 Chronological data

5.2.1 *Synchronism with the* dam en

A good starting point to order from a chronological perspective the lists of royal sons is the comparison with the lists of the court ladies (Tonietti 1989; see also Scarpa 2021a). So far, lists of dam en and dumu-nita en are co-attested in seven documents (see Table 5). Lists $\mathbf{R_{1\text{-}2}}$, $\mathbf{D_1}$, and $\mathbf{D_8}$[73] predate the royal wedding, since queen Tabur-damu either does not appear or is mentioned by her proper name.[74] List $\mathbf{D_8}$ dates to the years following her wedding to the king, while $\mathbf{M_4}$, $\mathbf{M_7}$, and $\mathbf{M_8}$ were written after Dusigu's death.

Archi (1988a, 222) already identified that list [75.1730] also mentions Ibbi-zikir as Ibrium's son and several court ladies of the oldest period (list $\mathbf{R_2}$). The document, later published as *M* 7 34, can be dated to the year of the royal wedding between Iš'ar-damu and Tabur-damu. The close link with list [75.2417] already identified by Archi depends on the fact that this document likewise dates to the year of the royal wedding. Particularly relevant is the lack of mention of other royal sons, such as *ar-wa* and *zu*$_{(2)}$*-du*, who will appear only in later lists. List $\mathbf{D_8}$ [75.1731+75.2498 = *A* XX 7 = *M* 7 35] is the second cross-reference document mentioning both royal sons and court ladies; Dusigu is still alive, and Tabur-damu is already queen.

5.2.2 *Group 1*

A careful analysis of the accounts that include dumu-nita en lists reveals the presence of references to the same important events. [75.1938] dates to Irkab-damu's death (Biga 2007–2008) and is probably

73. I follow the chronological sequence and nomenclature defined by Tonietti 1989.
74. Documents mentioning Tabur-damu by her name probably predate her wedding to Iš'ar-damu. Scribes address her as exclusively as *MA-LIK-TUM* after the royal wedding. See Bonechi 2016a, 57.

one of the oldest lists of Group 1, immediately following archaic list [75.1535 = *A* XV 26]. [75.1435 = *A* IV 13] and [75.1337 = *A* XIX 13] probably date to Ibrium's first years as a vizier (Samir 2019, 115). [75.1322+ = *A* XIX 8] presents a list of nar (rev.IV:8-V:7) similar to those Tonietti (1988, 99) identified as the most ancient. Similarly, [75.1748] and [75.2455] present two parallel lists of nar belonging to this same group. [75.1522] contains references to Dusigu's mother *A-da-da* and royal daughter *Ma-u*$_3$*-ud*; both were active during Ibrium's vizierate. All these documents thus belong to the years between Irkab-damu's death up to the royal wedding between Iš'ar-damu and Tabur-damu. In fact, [75.10153] also contains dam en list **D**$_1$, where queen *Da-bur-da-mu* is still mentioned by her name, and it dates along with [75.1730 = *M* 7 34] and [75.2417] to the year of Iš'ar-damu's and Tabur-damu's wedding.[75] Furthermore, according to Archi (1998, 44), [75.2358] dates to the year of Ibrium's death, while [75.1731+75.2498 = *A* XX 7 = *M* 7 35] mentions only his son Ibbi-zikir, who had probably already inherited his father's position (Archi 2018a, 45). Finally, [75.1681 = *A* IV 19 = *M* 7 34] mentions *Gi-mi*-NI-*a-du*'s death; the queen's sister passed away before lady Dusigu, since the latter does not appear among *Gi-mi*-NI-*a-du*'s deceased ancestors ([75.1681 = A IV 19 = *M* 7 34] obv.VII:9-IX:14; see also parallel text [75.1860 = *M* 10 20]). This document probably dates to Ibbi-zikir's first years as a vizier (Biga – Pomponio 1990, 180). [75.1792], [75.1427], [75.1706], [75.2368], and [75.2520] are almost entirely unpublished and cannot be dated.

Tablet	**dam en list**	**dumu-nita en list**
75.1730 = *M* 7 34	**R**$_1$ (rev.XIII:24-XIV:26)	Group 1 (rev.XII:11"-XIII:16)
75.2417	**R**$_2$ (rev.X:20-XI:12)	Group 1 (rev.IX:7-X:3)
75.10153	**D**$_1$ (obv.IX:15-X:15)	Group 1 (obv.VII:9-X:2)
75.1731+2498 = *A* XX 7 (= *M* 7 35)	**D**$_8$ (rev.XIII:5-XIV:13)	Group 1 (obv.IV:21-V:8)
75.1894	**M**$_4$ (rev.VI:20-VII:1)	Group 2 (obv.I:14-II:5)
75.10170	**M**$_7$ (rev.II:2-IV:2)	Group 2 (obv.I:14-II:5)
75.2328 = *A* XX 17	**M**$_8$ (rev.IV:1-27)	Group 2 (obv.VII:7-IX:8)

Table 5: Co-occurrences of dumu-nita en and dam en lists (classified according to Tonietti 1989).

5.2.3 *Group 2*

[75.1729] presents a list of ŠEŠ.II.IB among whom appears *Ru*$_{12}$*-zi-ma-lik*, Ibbi-zikir's son (Archi 2002b, 49). Biga suggested that this text was contemporary to [75.1868 = *A* IV 22], in which dam en list **M**$_1$ appears, and dated both tablets to Ibbi-zikir's first years as a vizier (Biga 1996, 70; 2008, 207).

[75.10229] obv.X:7-18 mentions the queen (= Tabur-damu) as well as *Ib-ḫar*-^{dingir}'*A*$_3$*-da* (obv.VIII:8, Ibbi-zikir's son) (Archi 1990, 37, 2010a, 5), and therefore dates after the royal wedding between Iš'ar-damu and Tabur-damu.

75. On the dam en lists, see Tonietti 1989; Scarpa 2021a. [75.10153] dates to the same year, immediately preceding the wedding; see Bonechi 2016a. In fact, [75.2417] registers a delivery for Titinu, who brought to Ebla the news of a positive omen concerning Tabur-damu and her role as queen of Ebla. [75.1730 = *M* 7 34] and [75.2417] have been recognized as parallel by Biga – Capomacchia 2012.

Several documents contain mentions of individuals belonging to the youngest generation, that of crown prince Ir'ag-damu's and Ibbi-zikir's son Dubuḫu-'Ada. The latter appears in [75.1894] obv.V:13, which also includes dam en list M_4 and thus dates after Dusigu's death (Archi 2002b, 51). Ir'ag-damu and Dubuḫu-'Ada both appear in [75.1446 = *A* IV 14]; [75.2335] mentions instead Ir'ag-damu's full-sister Kešdut (rev.V:12–20).[76] This document is contemporary to [75.2426], according to Archi and Biga (2003, 15).[77] [75.2275] rev.XII:4-11 also mentions Ir'ag-damu and Dubuḫu-'Ada.[78] Tablets [75.1255 = *A* IV 1] obv.VIII:1-4, [75.1436] obv.VII:9-29,[79] and [75.2270][80] mention Ir'ag-damu, his wife Za'aše, and his full sister Kešdut together with royal daughters of the same generation. [75.10170] contains dam en list M_7 (rev.II:2-IV:2); as with other documents of the *MA-LIK-TUM* series that include dam en lists (see Table 5), this tablet dates to after Dusigu's death, when Tabur-damu had already become queen. [75.2328 = *A* XX 17] rev.IV:1-27 contains dam en list M_8 and mentions one of Ibbi-zikir's sons (*Ru*$_{12}$-*zi-ma-lik*, obv.XII:1), as well as princess Kešdut (rev.III:12).

[75.2280] includes one of the two available transition lists; it mentions Groups 1 and 2 together. However, *I-da-ni-ki-mu*, *I-in*-^{dingir}'*A*$_3$-*da*, and *I*$_3$-*lum-a-ḫi* of Group 1 are missing; the reason of their absence, however, is not clear. This document dates to the year Ebla prevailed over Mari according to Archi (*i.e.* late Ibbi-zikir, Archi 2020, 45).

Finally, [75.2438] dates to Ibbi-zikir's first years (Biga 2006, 34).

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76. Biga 2010, 38.
77. See also Archi 2010a, 1.
78. Archi 1988b, 108 n. 13.
79. Mander 1988, 59. See also Biga – Pomponio 1990, 190, who date the text to early Ibbi-zikir.
80. I follow the chronological sequence and nomenclature defined by Tonietti 1989.

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